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Fickle Grief: COLLECTIVE Delhi Secretary Sourya's Full Statement Against the Posthumous Veneration of Ratan N. Tata

COLLECTIVE Delhi's General Secretary Sourya's full statement on the posthumous veneration of Ratan N. Tata — challenging the media narrative of ethical entrepreneurship with a record of the Tata Group's land acquisitions, displacement of communities, and the selective memory that public mourning makes both possible and convenient.

BY SOURYA

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ABOUT

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Following is the full statement by COLLECTIVE Delhi's General Secretary, Sourya against the largely positive posthumous regard for Tata Group's late chairman, Ratan N. Tata, that has taken the world & Internet by storm in the wake of his passing on 9th October 2024. The billionaire industrialist, who succumbed to natural causes at the age of 86, has been lauded as a visionary by politicians & public figures both in India & around the world, & these comments have received widespread media coverage over the last 24 hours.

Beyond media coverage, a proposal for awarding Tata a posthumous Bharat Ratna has already been tabled by the Chief Minister of Maharashtra, Eknath Shinde, who has also announced that a 'State funeral' will be organised for him, as reported by mint^[1] (sic). This despite the fact that Tata himself was vocally against receiving the Bharat Ratna, & had requested the efforts to award him one to be stopped back in 2021 during a campaign for his nomination for the same. Zee TV founder & billionaire Subhash Chandra Goenka has also announced a biopic.¹

Through the hours of 10AM to 4PM today, 10th October 2024, Tata's body was kept on public display so that the 'public could pay their respects', & the same beginning with VIP visits to the body till the last rites conducted with 'full state honour' was broadcasted live on national television across news channels.² The following testimony heavily criticizes this posthumous veneration of the industry giant by public figures & the media alike, & calls out the hypocrisy of glorifying an individual post their death when that perspective remained absent, or even antagonistic, during their life.

Prior to his death, Tata's mega-corporation has repeatedly been accused of negligence & hazardous working conditions under his chairmanship, resulting in several employee deaths, & has remained controversial for its close involvement with ruling governments & land acquisition projects. Recently, the Tata Group had also been supplying automobiles to the Israeli military for use in the Occupied West Bank. Read the report here.^[2]

(Originally written on 9th October 2024): "Today, the 'leftist' Chief Minister of Kerala³ and a billionaire from Gujarat⁴ are both paying tribute to Ratan Tata. It is a matter of great pride for any individual when ideological opponents come together in mourning, but this reflects something deeper.

After the advent of neoliberalism and the resurgence of capitalism in Soviet Russia and China, many scholars celebrated what they deemed the 'end of ideologies.' This was also referred to as "there is no alternative" (TINA). Over the past three decades, multinational companies like Tata and Adani have reached historic heights of dominance, yet the country has seen increases in malnutrition, unemployment, displacement, and communal, casteist, and patriarchal frenzy. According to statistics, today, the level of inequality in the country is greater than during British rule. This is not merely coincidental.

The memorial for 13 martyrs in Kalinga Nagar, Odisha, remains a proud symbol of tribal resistance. These martyrs rose against Tata Steel, wielding bows and arrows to protect their cultural and natural heritage. When the country's first 'Special Economic Zone' was established in Bengal during the CPI (Marxist) regime in 2003, Tata and Indonesia's Salem Group were its first consumers. In Singur and Nandigram, landless and small farmers were forcibly evicted from their land, and the red flag was crushed by this very government. The Tata Nano plant in Singur, heralded as a model of leftist industrialization, later moved to Sanand, Gujarat. The reality is that thousands of farmers were displaced, providing jobs to only 200 permanent and 1,800 contract workers.

In 2015, when demands for a union arose against falling real wages, union leadership was illegally ousted. The truth of this anti-people 'development' has been laid bare as statistics from the last two decades show that despite the creation of land banks and concessions in labour laws to attract private and foreign investment, employment in production has declined rather than increased. Tea plantation workers who grow Tata Tea are now facing the police to unite in Darjeeling. From Kashmir to Manipur and Nagaland, Tata trucks and drones are merely another name for military rule.

On one hand, to ideologically defend their profit-based system, Tata Steel has established institutions like the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) and Tata Environment Research Institute (TERI) using their financial clout; on the other hand, to pit the oppressed against each other, private militias like Salwa Judum and Operation Green Hunt have been funded by houses like Tata and Jindal. Beyond Tata, fishermen from Kerala to Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Bengal are fighting against Adani Port. There seems to be no alternative to this inhumane model of 'development' from either the ruling or opposition parties.

It is said that one should not criticise a person after their death. Well, even during Ratan Tata's lifetime, we have spoken ill of him and will continue to do so; a life of luxury and comfort tends to reflect a certain soft sensitivity and generosity on a person's face. A hungry child, writhing with hunger, may grab his brother's collar and say, "Give me food, you bastard." It takes centuries and billions of wealth for newly emerged capitalists, who flee their society after violence, to achieve such an innocent image.

But regardless of their façade, despite a thousand personal virtues, the harsh rule of profit forces them to commit crimes every day. Without this, it is impossible to exploit a person's labour without giving fair compensation. In a class-divided society, a universal definition of humanity, justice, law, and morality is not possible. To make this a reality, revolutionary preparations are underway in the very womb of the working masses worldwide. Sometimes this emerges in sharp struggles, sometimes it takes the form of a dead peace. In such a scenario, we are compelled to choose sides, and remaining silent is a grave sin."

Sourya is a PhD scholar at JNU & the General Secretary of COLLECTIVE's Delhi branch. COLLECTIVE⁽³⁾ is a student-led non-profit working in areas of worker's rights & political activism. Since 2017, COLLECTIVE has established a short but powerful portfolio of investigative journalism, including a fact-finding report on the horrific Anaj Mandi factory fire⁽⁴⁾, where 43 people died. Its constitution & programme describe it as a 'left-revolutionary' student organisation.

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